THE PRICE OF DAWN — SESSION 4: THE BREAKING POINT

Official GM Adventure Module · Level 7 (Calibrated for 5 Gestalt PCs) · Dilemma: *What do you owe to people who choose to sacrifice themselves?*

SESSION 4 - THE BREAKING POINT (LEVEL 7)

Dilemma: What do you owe to people who choose to sacrifice themselves?

QUICK REFERENCE CARD

GM Balance Note: 5 Gestalt Level 7 Characters (10-Player Equivalent)

This session is tuned for **5 Gestalt Level 7 characters**. Because dual-class characters possess double the resource pool, features, and action synergies, they should be balanced as **10 Level 7 characters** (Deadly Encounter Budget: **17,000+ XP**). - Bosses and elite commanders possess **Legendary Resistances**, **Anti-Magic auras**, and **high HP pools** (175–195 HP) to prevent single-turn shutdowns from focused smites and burst spells. - Use the provided GM tactics and focus fire on isolated party members to maintain dramatic tension.

Level	7 · ~3–4 hours · Opener + 5 scenes
Session dilemma	What do you owe to people who choose to sacrifice themselves?
Session arc	Revelation → Confrontation → Discovery → Doubt → Ultimatum
Three factions	Concordance of the Withdrawn (corrupting the ritual), The Flowering (capturing Ixa), The Restorers (persuadable - same as Maerin Voss)
Session goal	Collect 8 ritual cubes from the 8 living Dawnborn by earning their genuine consent
The puzzle box	Corven's Concordance Stone - 8 slots, each cube = one Dawnborn's consent. Assembled correctly and lit: projects a dawn bird. This is the ritual activation signal.

NPC	WANT	FEAR	LIE
Ellan Voss	Someone to ask the right question	That she will say yes too late	*"I will not give consent. Not before."*
Maerin Voss	Sera to change her mind	She is already too late	*"I'm not asking you to say no"*
Harran Lecht	To solve the crisis before the city starves	Grief has made him impatient in ways he cannot see	*"This is purely strategic"*
Cormac Drell	To not have to decide again	Everyone will see his uncertainty collapse	His nine-weeks-ago yes is still the same yes
Ysel Maren	The Inversion to succeed, all ten willing	Cormac's wavering will spread to others	She is not frightened herself
Aldric Stone	To help; he has already chosen	That he chose wrong	He is not afraid of dying

FACTION OVERVIEW - THREE ACTIVE THREATS

1. Concordance of the Withdrawn

Symbol: An obsidian disc with an inward-facing crescent. Worn inside clothing. Never displayed openly.

What they say they are: A philosophical order honoring Auris's completed departure. They teach that the sun's fading was a natural cosmological transition rather than a tragedy. In their view, restoring sunlight is divine necromancy that violates the god's passage, and they guard this threshold against interference.

What they actually are: An organization directed by an ancient Lich known as the Unmoved One. The Lich does not care about theology; it wants to corrupt the Inversion, redirecting the ritual's energy to extinguish lingering light and turn Varenhold into a perpetual dark domain under its rule. Rank-and-file members believe the faith; leadership follows the Lich's directives.

History: The Concordance did not exist before the Twilight. It formed in the first decade after the sun stopped - originally a genuine grief-theology, a community of people who needed a way to understand the loss that wasn't "we failed." The Unmoved One found them approximately thirty years ago. It did not announce itself. It worked slowly, through intermediaries, through a doctrine of increasing rigidity, through the careful removal of anyone who asked the wrong questions. The current leadership (the Priests of the Inward Crescent) are almost entirely in the dark about what sits above them in the chain of command. The chain is three tiers: the Unlit (street operatives, cell-based), the Priests (doctrine and operations), and the Unmoved (the Lich and its chosen agents). No Priest has met the Unmoved One directly. They receive sealed orders. They follow them.

Thirty years of activity: Watching the Dawnborn. Tracking anyone who got too close to the Inversion's mechanics. Removing obstacles - not through violence when it could be avoided, but through bureaucracy, information suppression, rumour, strategic placement of loyal individuals in city institutions. Keseph Vyne (Warden of the Amber Compact) is not a member; he is a convenient collaborator who profits from the same permanent twilight the Concordance needs. They have a working arrangement, not loyalty.

This session: They lost their Dusk Priest in Session 3. The Solennite Blades in Scene 1 are Concordance-contracted - not ideologically aligned, simply hired. Their seer watches the open streets. They know the party visited Ellan Voss. They are not moving yet. They are waiting for the party to do enough of the work (assembling the Dawnborn, locating the ritual sequence) before moving to corrupt rather than prevent. Stopping the party early helps nobody. Letting them get close, then redirecting, is the plan.

Keseph Vyne (collaborator, not member) - Warden of the Amber Compact. Has suppressed Archive documents since Session 1. He profits from fifty years of twilight: amber trade monopolies, supply contracts, a political structure built entirely around permanent dark. The Concordance tolerates him because he does their suppression work for financial reasons, which is cleaner than ideological cooperation. - *Want:* The current arrangement to outlast anyone who would disrupt it. - *Fear:* The sun returns and his position is worthless overnight. - *Lie:* "This is a Compact security matter." It is a financial matter.

Posture this session: Scene 1 (Solennite Blades intercept). Background observation throughout. No direct move until Session 5 when the Inversion looks likely to complete.

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2. The Flowering

Symbol: A bloom with one petal too many, center darker than it should be. Left somewhere visible as an invitation.

What they say they are: A sanctuary and mutual-aid family. They welcome outcasts, interspecies couples, and individuals who fall outside Varenhold's rigid classifications. Fifty years ago, they sheltered Ellan Voss and now seek whatever became of her child.

What they actually are: An isolated commune warped by decades of magical experimentation. Originally an honest haven, they eventually turned to manipulating ambient twilight radiation to reshape biology. Their mutated failures remain among them: deformed, cared for, and treated as family.

Leader: Known only as the Gardener, an ancient, hidden figure. The Gardener believes transcendent life can be cultivated from twilight energy and views Ixa as living proof of this theory.

History: Founded in the early Twilight in unpoliced slums and abandoned cellars. For twenty years they were an honest sanctuary, but later turned to biological experimentation using the ambient energy that produced Ixa.

What they want this session: Ixa. They offer belonging, kinship, and answers about her heritage, hoping she joins them voluntarily. If rejected or opposed, they send mutated retrieval squads to bring her in by force.

Posture this session: Active approach - a private letter arrives for Ixa between Scenes 3 and 4. If Ixa engages or the party investigates the letter's origin, The Flowering makes a direct move. If Ixa ignores it: the move comes at the end of Scene 4, just before the Reckoning escalation. See new encounter block below.

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3. The Restorers

Symbol: Two crossed lanterns, flame at both ends. Worn openly; they are not secret.

What they say they are: The Society for the Return of Auris's Light. An open, disciplined fellowship dedicated to correcting the historical failure of the ritual and restoring the sun.

What they actually are: Sincere, devout zealots. They are not corrupt or infiltrated; they genuinely believe dying in the ritual is a sacred completion rather than a tragic cost. Their conviction makes them dangerous because they view hesitation as selfish in the face of widespread suffering.

Leader: Brother Edoran, a charismatic former archivist in his late forties. Passionate and persuasive, he is convinced that ten willing Dawnborn will restore the sun. His critical blind spot is consent: he treats social guilt and moral obligation as acceptable substitutes for free will.

Maerin Voss is a Restorer. She carries the priest's cord at her wrist. She has not told Ellan Voss directly - she has been working around Ellan's refusal for three years, hoping that the right evidence, the right moment, the right conversation would move her. She is not a fanatic. She is someone who believes she is helping and is not sure anymore whether she is.

History: Founded in Year 5 of the Twilight by a former participant in Corven's original ritual - not a Dawnborn, but one of the supporting circle. He watched the ritual fail at the ninth position, spent the rest of his life trying to understand why, and died without seeing a second attempt. The organisation he built outlasted him. It has been meeting weekly for forty-nine years. It has a library. It has a doctrine. It has been waiting.

Posture this session: Not a combat threat. Maerin Voss is present in the opener. If players are struggling against the Concordance or the Flowering, the Restorers can be persuaded (DC 13 Persuasion, or simply by sharing evidence of either faction's actual agenda) to act as active allies - they will provide intelligence, bodies, and sanctuary. They are convinced enemies of the Concordance's theology. Pointing Edoran at the Concordance's true goal (eternal night, not sacred passage) is the fastest way to make him a furious and very organised problem for the Concordance.

SESSION OPENER - THE STONE IS GIVEN

Session 4 begins here: the party is leaving Ashring Third Lane with Ellan Voss. The Concordance has been watching this street for three years. They have minutes before someone moves.

Five Senses & Setup

Setup: Ashring Third Lane, early amber hour. The street is quiet, but lookouts watch from both ends.

Five senses: - *Sight:* A motionless watcher at the street corner; another visible on a rooftop opposite. Neither makes an effort to hide. - *Sound:* Low, irregular humming from the Ashring stones nearby. - *Smell:* Wet stone, coal smoke, cold air. - *Touch:* Faint warmth radiating from Ellan's doorway; freezing amber chill elsewhere. - *Air:* Still and sharp.

Ellan Hands Over the Stone

Before reaching the street corner, Ellan stops.

She reaches into her coat and presents the Concordance Stone.

The octagonal stone vessel fills two hands, dense and solid. Eight empty sockets line the rim, each faintly warm to the touch.

> *"Corven built this. Each cavity belongs to one Dawnborn - their consent made object. Place all eight correctly, in the astronomical order of the ritual night, brightest star to dimmest, and shine any light through the aperture at the top. What it projects is the signal. Every stone in the Ashring will know it is time."*

She looks at each of them.

> *"You cannot force what goes into it. The cavity reads intention. It must be given freely or it will not seat. I have tried, with my own, many times. It knows."*

The eight cubes belong to: Sera Voss, Tomas Areth, Lira Anwick, Aldric Stone, Cormac Drell, Ysel Maren, Petra Vane, and Davin Shore.

Where to start: Sera Voss. She has been tracking the Dawnborn for years and knows where each one is.

Ellan's own consent is not a cube. She gives it at the circle itself. She has already decided. She will not say so until she is standing on her stone.

The watcher at the lane's end does not intercept. She is counting faces. DC 15 Perception: she looks specifically at Ixa's hands, then looks away. She is not Concordance. She is Flowering. They are not the only ones who know what Ixa is.

Session 3 Recap - Already Played

The ward mechanic, Ellan's key speech, the Maerin/Sera confrontation, and the Ixa recognition beat all played in Session 3. Do not repeat them. The opener above picks up immediately after.

WHAT CARRIED FORWARD	STATUS
"We need to speak with her"	Cold. A task, not a reason.
"To save the city"	Cold. A mission, not consent.
"Because I need to understand how someone says no to something this important"	**Click.**
"I follow my companions"	Cold. Obligation is not consent. They must find their own reason.
"I am afraid of what happens if I don't"	**Click.** Vulnerability counts.

Anyone who cannot find a real reason stands outside. The door stays open. That is its own answer.

Hint timing: 10 real minutes before any hint. Then Sera (if present): *"It's not asking you to say the word. It's asking you to do it."* Five more minutes: Sera steps to the panel and speaks her own reason. Click.

Maerin's Arrival

Mid-thirties, sharp and purposeful, bearing a distinct family resemblance to Ellan. She wears an Auris priest's cord at her wrist with practical confidence rather than penitence.

She appears as the last player speaks their reason - coming around the corner of the lane, moving fast, alone. She takes in the door, the panel, the party. She does not explain how she found it.

She steps to the panel and speaks her own reason without being invited. Not dramatic. The ward clicks.

She looks at whoever is nearest: *"I know this door. I know what's inside. Let me go first."*

She does not wait. She goes in.

Ellan - Key Lines & The Iza Beat

Ellan answers the door before they finish reading the letter in the compartment.

Silver-grey hair cropped short, slight frame, with steady amber eyes. Her hands are remarkably steady despite years under watch. She looks each adventurer over carefully. When she notices Iza, her gaze lingers for a fraction of a second.

> ***GM - If Ixa is in the party [LOCKED: players do not know this]***
>
> *When Ellan glances at Ixa, she notices her hands and hesitates briefly before resuming a neutral expression. She checks Ixa's hands once more before the conversation concludes, without offering an explanation.*
>
> ***What Ellan does not know:*** *She knows she lost a child during the ritual's collapse fifty years ago. She does not know the Crucible took that infant and designated her IX-A (marking her mother's ritual position). She has spent fifty years believing both daughters died.*
>
> ***The campaign truth:*** *Ixa is the price of dawn. The overflow energy from Ellan's withdrawal passed directly into her unborn child. Returning that energy in Session 5 is the central dilemma.*
>
> ***For Ixa's player:*** *Perception DC 14 to catch Ellan watching her hands; DC 17 to spot that their hands share an identical narrow bone structure.*

"Theron finally sent someone. Good. Come in."

If players ask why she mentions Theron: She has not seen Theron in forty years. While she initially blamed him for the catastrophe, she now views the failure as an inevitable structural flaw in the ritual's design.

(If asked what Theron did to revive Iza, Ellan directs them to Theron: "He took something from the Ashring to restart her heart. That is his burden to explain, not mine." She harbors no personal bitterness, but insists he answer for it himself.)

She pours hot tea, keeping a quiet eye on Iza while discussing plans with the party.

Key lines:

> *"The ritual didn't fail because the cost was wrong. It failed because I withdrew my consent at the last moment. I was the ninth. I said no. And because I said no, it ended."*

If asked why:

She is quiet. Long enough that it stops feeling like a pause.

> *"I was pregnant."*

She does not elaborate immediately. She looks at her hands.

> *"She was - I was five months. Her father had died the winter before. The child was the last thing he left me. The last proof that something had been real between us, between two people who deserved more time than they got. I stood at my stone. I understood what the ritual required. I wanted to give it. I had told myself for months that I would."*

> *"Then I felt her move. And I understood: she had not consented. She had not been asked. She was not nine people with a choice - she was one person inside me who had no voice yet, and I was about to give that voice away. On her behalf. Without asking."*

> *"The ritual required everything. I could not give everything that was not mine to give."*

Silence.

> *"She was born that night. During the aftermath. The ritual failed, the sun stopped, and she was born, and she did not breathe."*

> *"They told me she did not breathe."*

A long silence. She picks up her cup. Sets it back down.

> *"I have been living in that silence for fifty years."*

> *"The Dawnless found out I existed approximately three years ago. They have been keeping me alive because I am useful to them. If the ritual proceeds, it requires my consent. I will not give it. Not because I am afraid. Because I am the only person in this city who has seen what happens when someone changes their mind at the last second inside the circle."*

If asked "Will you say yes now?": *> Long silence. Then: "Ask me again when you've found all ten. Ask me again when they've all had the chance to choose freely. Then ask me. Not before."*

The Iza beat - choose one trigger before the session, tell no one else:

Ellan never saw her newborn's face. What triggers recognition are family mannerisms: how Iza holds her hands, her posture, and understated expressions reminiscent of her father.

OPTION	HOW IT PLAYS
Iza makes a quiet, precise observation	Ellan sets her cup down and watches Iza closely for the rest of the visit.
"Your name; how did you come to have it?"	Ellan deflects into etymology and history, visibly buying time to process her reaction.
Parting line: *"You were never an experiment. You were the reason."*	Ellan addresses Iza directly, letting the words stand without elaboration.

Maerin & Sera - Confrontation

The exchange is quiet and tense.

Maerin, confronting Sera: *"Nine others. You are one. Why must you decide first?"*

Sera: *"Because someone has to."*

Maerin: *"That's not an answer."*

Sera: *"It's the only answer I have."*

Players can intervene, but neither woman will back down. Both speak from valid convictions hardened by years of hardship.

- **Maerin wants:** To hear Sera say she changed her mind. She will not get it.
- **Maerin fears:** That she is too late to be part of whatever comes next.
- **Maerin lies:** *"I'm not asking you to say no."* She absolutely is.

Sera's Warning & Cliffhanger

Sera's warning - as they prepare to leave:

> *"The Reckoning has been asking about you by name. Not description - name. Someone gave them your names specifically. That's not standard intelligence work."*

She offers no further details.

GM note: This plants the Harran personal stake before Scene 5. Players who remember this line when Harran names Maren Drel will feel the thread connect.

Cliffhanger: As they leave, Ellan says - not dramatically, just factually: *"The Dawnless will know you came here. They watch this street. They have for three years."*

She closes the door.

SCENE 1 - COMBAT: CONCORDANCE UNLIT CELL

Five Senses & Setup

Five senses: - *Sight:* Morning along the Ashring road. Five figures block the lane in disciplined positions, weapons sheathed, motionless as headstones. Frost has settled on their shoulders. They have been standing here long enough for the cold to mean something. - *Sound:* The street is dead quiet - not empty, silenced. Ahead, the faint, irregular hum of the Ashring stones, like something breathing underwater. - *Smell:* Cold flagstones, dry ozone, and beneath it the cloying sweetness of temple incense, the kind burned in rooms where someone has died. - *Touch:* Uneven, frost-heaved cobblestones underfoot. The air near the five figures is colder than it should be. - *Air:* Still, chilled amber dusk. No wind. The five figures don't shift in it. They don't shift at all.

Setup: Five Concordance Unlit operatives intercept the party en route to the Ashring. Zealous followers who consider the sun's return a cosmic violation, their orders are to turn the party back and intimidate them rather than execute them - but their doctrine permits killing to hold the passage, and each of them has already decided they would. They do not want this fight. They have simply stopped being afraid of it. The moment the party spills blood, the cell stops trying to frighten them and starts trying to end them.

The Unlit will not run while the Shadow-Keeper stands. When the Shadow-Keeper falls, the survivors mark the party - a cut across the palm, a name whispered into the dark - and spend one final round in unbroken fury before withdrawing, dragging their wounded and leaving their dead where they fell. The road stays slick for a long time after.

The watcher: A sixth figure, never in the encounter itself - an older shadar-kai woman standing in a doorway twenty feet back, watching. If players move toward her, she steps inside and the door closes. She is the cell's upward contact. She does not fight. She is memorising faces. DC 15 Perception to notice her before she leaves. She is not afraid. She is writing the report in her head, and the report has already decided what the party are.

Secondary Objective (state before combat begins): Take one Unlit operative alive. A captured operative carries a sealed document tube - inside, a partial asset list with the designation SUNRISE-4 (Sera Voss) and IX (Ellan Voss). The handwriting is two different people's. The document is too precise to be operational notes; it is a surveillance summary. Someone has been watching the Dawnborn for a long time and has them categorised.

Taking one alive is the hard path. The Unlit would rather die than be questioned, and they have been trained to make it difficult. An operative reduced to 0 HP who is not stabilised within two rounds bleeds out on the road - and the Voice, if it still stands, will finish the wounded itself rather than leave them to talk. The document tube is on the first operative to fall, not the last.

Enemies, Objectives & Tactics

Enemies - 5 combatants total (gestalt encounter, CR ~9):

Unlit Operative ×3 - *Medium humanoid (shadar-kai)* Ash-grey skin and jet-black eyes in tailored charcoal coats, the cut of them precise in a way that says *made for this*. Disciplined stealth skirmishers who flank and shadow-step - and they fight to kill, not to wound. Each one carries a small blade at the small of the back that has already tasted blood. → *Full stat block: Combat Cards section below. CR 5 each.*

Unlit Shadow-Keeper ×1 - *Medium humanoid (shadar-kai, cell commander)* Tall shadar-kai officer wearing an exposed obsidian crescent pendant. Wields a dark iron shortsword and null-focus rod. Their eyes move from party member to party member with the specific calm of someone who has already decided which one to kill first. → *Full stat block: Combat Cards section below. CR 8.*

Unlit Doctrinal Voice ×1 - *Medium humanoid (human, theological officer)* Unarmed spokesman in his mid-fifties. Speaks with flat, unshakeable authority while preparing defensive abjurations. He carries no weapon; this is not because he is unarmed. He has presided over executions before and his hands do not shake. → *Full stat block: Combat Cards section below. CR 7 (spellcasting).*

Combat ends when: The Shadow-Keeper is reduced to 0 HP. The remaining Unlit do not flee. They mark the party, fight one final round of unbroken fury, and then withdraw - dragging their wounded, leaving their dead where they fell. The Doctrinal Voice, if it still stands, holds its ground long enough to say one line before turning away: *"You were warned. The record will show you were warned."* It does not run. It walks, and its eyes find each party member in turn before it is gone.

What players learn: The Concordance has been tracking the Dawnborn by designation. The surveillance is older than the party's involvement. The cell structure means capturing one operative will not give them much, but the document tube will give them the designations and confirm the surveillance scope. And if they look at the bodies afterward - at the ring on one finger, the locket under one coat - they will understand that these are not hired killers. These are people who believed, all the way down.

Tactical notes: - Formation: Voice at rear (30 ft. back), Shadow-Keeper center, three Operatives forward across the road. They are not encircling - the flanks are open. They are expecting the party to stop and negotiate. They are wrong. - Terrain: Road narrows between an old garden wall (three-quarters cover, left) and Ashring outer marker stones (half cover, right). No cover in the road itself. - The Operatives shadow-step if the party tries to break through; they do not need to run to close gaps. - The Voice does not move forward

under any circumstances. - **Lethal doctrine:** An Unlit adjacent to an incapacitated creature (paralyzed, unconscious, hypnotized) spends its action to deliver a killing stroke - an automatic critical hit, no attack roll. The Voice's *hold person* is not crowd control. It is a death sentence with a delay, and the cell knows exactly how to serve it.

The Opening - Before Initiative

The Doctrinal Voice speaks in a clear, measured tone. He does not need to raise it. They are close enough that he doesn't.

> *"The door has closed. We are asking you, politely and for the first time, to stop walking toward it."*

They wait. If the party moves forward, or draws weapons, or makes any hostile gesture:

> *"We understand you believe you are helping. The Concordance understands this about everyone who has stood where you are standing. They all believed they were helping."*

One beat of silence.

> *"None of them could tell us what happened to the people who lived in this city after a forced reopening. Because there was no after."*

Then they stop talking. The Shadow-Keeper draws their shortsword, and the sound it makes leaving the sheath is very small and very final.

Social path: DC 14 Persuasion gets the Voice to consider a counter-argument. On success, they agree to relay terms upward, stalling the ambush for 30 minutes. DC 18 Persuasion (or revealing the Unmoved One's corruption scheme) visibly shakes the Voice's composure, causing a hesitation before combat triggers - and in that hesitation the Shadow-Keeper has already begun to move.

If the party spills blood first - any blood - the Voice does not negotiate further. It speaks one word in a language none of them know, and the cell stops trying to turn the party back and starts trying to kill them. The doctrine is clear on this point. So are they.

The Obsidian Ring of Contrariwise - Item Reference

Found on the Shadow-Keeper if searched after combat.

Cursed Item, requires attunement (automatic on wearing, the ring attunes itself)

A Concordance interrogation tool. Designed to invert a subject's dominant personality traits for the purposes of breaking operational security or turning agents. The inversion is total, compulsive, and deeply confusing to the wearer, who retains full awareness of what they are doing while being completely unable to stop.

Effect: While attuned, the wearer acts against their dominant nature - the greedy give things away, the obedient defy orders, the aggressive become helpful, the cautious become reckless. The wearer knows exactly what they're doing. They can't stop.

In combat: +2 bonus to attack rolls and damage (the ring inverts caution; the wearer fights harder than intended). On a natural 1 or 2, the attack redirects to the nearest ally within reach. The wearer watches it happen and cannot prevent it.

d6 Compulsion Table — roll when the ring first attunes, or any time the GM wants to underscore the inversion:

D6	DOMINANT TRAIT	COMPELLED BEHAVIOUR
1	Secretive	Must answer every direct question truthfully — including ones they would die to protect
2	Aggressive	Must assist anyone who asks, including enemies; cannot refuse a request in good faith
3	Cautious	Must act on the first impulse, immediately, without planning or preparation
4	Loyal / obedient	Every instruction received becomes the opposite of what they do
5	Acquisitive	Anything they carry that someone visibly needs, they hand over unprompted
6	Controlled / stoic	Every internal reaction surfaces immediately, at full volume, in front of whoever is present

Weaponisable: Slip the ring onto a captured operative or Concordance member. Roll d6 for their dominant trait. A Priest with result 1 or 4 answers questions they have spent years sealing away. The Concordance trains against most interrogation methods. They do not train for this one because it was their tool.

Removal: *Remove Curse* (DC 15) or Wisdom saving throw DC 20 after 24 hours of rest. The wearer physically resists removal attempts, not because they want to, but because the ring wants to.

What it tells players: If brought to Theron, he identifies it immediately and looks extremely troubled. *"They were using these on people. To break them."* He takes a moment. *"That's significantly worse than I thought they were."* The ring has been in the Shadow-Keeper's possession for years. It has the wear of something they have used before.

Combat Cards - Full Stat Blocks

UNLIT OPERATIVE *(×3) Medium humanoid (shadar-kai), lawful neutral*

AC 15 (studded leather) · **HP** 65 (10d8+20) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)

Saving Throws Dex +7, Wis +5 · **Skills** Stealth +9, Perception +5, Deception +3, Athletics +4 **Damage Resistances** Necrotic · **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 15 · **Languages** Common, Elvish · **CR** 5 (1,800 XP)

TRAITS

Shadow Step (Bonus Action, Recharge 4–6). While in dim light or darkness, teleports up to 30 ft. to another dim or dark space. Arrives with advantage on the first melee attack before end of turn. Varenhold's amber twilight always qualifies.

Cell Discipline. Cannot be charmed or frightened. Knows nothing above their own cell - a captured Operative cannot reveal names or locations they do not have.

Pack Tactics. Advantage on attack rolls against a creature when at least one ally is within 5 ft. of it.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Two Shortsword attacks.

Shortsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d6+4) piercing.

Hand Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d6+4) piercing.

REACTIONS

Fade. When reduced to 0 HP, the Operative makes one final Shadow Step before falling - a last reflexive wrench of the dark, as if the body is trying to crawl back into the shadow it came from. They arrive unconscious at the new location, bleeding out; if no one reaches them within two rounds, they die alone in the half-dark. The blood they leave behind does not teleport with them.

> *Tactics: Open at range, Shadow Step into melee when an ally is adjacent. Prioritise flanking over frontal engagement. At 15 HP: Shadow Step to cover and switch to crossbow only. Will not pursue a fleeing target; will instead finish a downed one. When the Shadow-Keeper falls, each operative spends its last action in a final, reckless attack with advantage - their last gift to a dying commander - before withdrawing. They do not run. They walk, dragging their wounded, and they will remember the party's faces.*

UNLIT SHADOW-KEEPER *(×1) Medium humanoid (shadar-kai), lawful neutral*

AC 17 (chain mail + shield) · **HP** 112 (15d8+45) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)

Saving Throws Str +6, Con +6, Wis +6 · **Skills** Perception +6, Stealth +6, Athletics +6, Insight +6 **Damage Resistances** Necrotic · **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 16 · **Languages** Common, Elvish, Undercommon · **CR** 8 (3,900 XP)

TRAITS

Shadow Step (Bonus Action, Recharge 4–6). Teleports up to 30 ft. between dim/dark spaces. Advantage on next melee attack.

Cell Command. When the Shadow-Keeper uses Shadow Step, all Operatives within 30 ft. may use their reaction to make one weapon attack.

Twilight Awareness. Cannot be surprised while in dim light or darkness. Perceives invisible creatures within 15 ft. as blurred silhouettes (DC 14 to pinpoint).

Doctrine Hold. Immune to spells that would read its thoughts or compel truth. It does not know why - the Concordance administered something years ago that it accepted without question.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Three Shortsword attacks or two Shortsword + one Shadow Drain.

Shortsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6+3) piercing + 7 (2d6) necrotic.

Shadow Drain. *Ranged Spell Attack:* +6 to hit, range 60 ft. *Hit:* 14 (4d6) necrotic damage. Target's speed is halved until end of its next turn.

Enveloping Dark (Recharge 5–6). 15-ft radius, centered on self: dim light becomes darkness for 1 minute (concentration). Creatures in the darkness that aren't shadar-kai must succeed DC 14 Constitution save or be blinded until they leave the area.

REACTIONS

Interpose Shadow. When an ally within 10 ft. is hit, the Shadow-Keeper takes half the damage instead (split equally).

> *Tactics: Opens with Enveloping Dark. Shadow Steps to the melee frontliner and holds pressure. Uses Cell Command to direct Operative attacks each time it repositions. Does not slow at 30 HP. Fights until 0. When reduced to 0 HP, the Shadow-Keeper's body goes rigid for a single heartbeat - then the obsidian disc at its throat cracks, and something cold leaves it, and it is dead before it hits the ground with a thin smile that has nothing to do with the party. It died exactly the way it always assumed it would.*

UNLIT DOCTRINAL VOICE *(×1) Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral*

AC 13 (mage armor) · **HP** 84 (13d8+26) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Int +7, Wis +6 · **Skills** Arcana +7, History +7, Insight +6, Persuasion +5 **Senses** Passive Perception 13 · **Languages** Common, Elvish, Dwarvish, Infernal · **CR** 7 (2,900 XP)

Spellcasting. 9th-level spellcaster. Intelligence (save DC 15, +7 to hit).

Cantrips: toll the dead, minor illusion, chill touch, message *1st (4 slots):* shield, silent image, sleep *2nd (3 slots):* hold person, darkness, misty step *3rd (3 slots):* counterspell, fear, hypnotic pattern *4th (2 slots):* banishment, greater invisibility

TRAITS

Doctrinal Certainty. Immune to being charmed. Advantage on Wisdom saving throws. If a spell attempts to alter its beliefs or compel action against its doctrine, the spell automatically fails, treat as legendary resistance (3/day).

Back Line. Never moves within 30 ft. of a player voluntarily.

ACTIONS

Toll the Dead (Cantrip). One creature within 60 ft.: DC 15 Wis save or 9 (2d8) necrotic - 2d12 if missing HP.

Hold Person (2nd slot). One humanoid within 60 ft.: DC 15 Wis save or paralyzed 1 minute. Repeat end of each turn.

Fear (3rd slot). 30-ft cone: DC 15 Wis save or frightened 1 minute. Dash away from Voice on frightened creature's turn.

Hypnotic Pattern (3rd slot). 30-ft cube within 120 ft.: DC 15 Wis save or incapacitated and speed 0 until damaged or shaken. Concentration.

Banishment (4th slot). One creature within 60 ft.: DC 15 Cha save or banished to harmless demiplane for 1 minute (concentration). If concentration breaks before then, returns.

Greater Invisibility (4th slot). Self only. Invisible for 1 minute. Concentration.

REACTIONS Shield (1st slot, +5 AC, negates magic missile). Counterspell (3rd slot).

> *Tactics: Stays at maximum range throughout. Opens with Hold Person on the melee frontliner, then Hypnotic Pattern on a clustered group - and signals an Operative to finish whichever target drops. Fear if the party advances. Greater Invisibility on itself at 50% HP and moves away. Banishment only if a party member is doing something that cannot be countered otherwise. Counterspells all healing - it will not let the party drag anyone back from the edge. Never engages in melee. When one of its allies delivers a killing stroke, it does not react; it has presided over this before. If all allies go down: turns invisible and walks away, but not before its eyes*

> *find each party member in turn, memorising them the way the watcher in the doorway memorised them. Files its report within the hour.*

SCENE 2 - THE DIAGNOSTIC CIRCLE: WHAT THE STONES REMEMBER

Setup & The Empty Box

The Dusk Priest's defeat in Session 3 agitated the Ashring. The megaliths now hum with a heavy, rhythmic pulse.

The hidden hollow: DC 12 Investigation to spot passively; DC 8 if players search the dais deliberately. An eight-sided stone vessel lies tucked beneath the central platform. Eight empty sockets line its rim, waiting to be fitted.

What it is: Corven's *Concordance Stone*, an octagonal puzzle box serving as the mechanical trigger for the Inversion. Eight Ritual Cubes held by the living Dawnborn fit into its slots in astronomical order. When complete and illuminated, the box projects a dawn-bird glyph that initiates the ritual.

Where are the cubes? Each living Dawnborn received theirs from Corven fifty years ago, shortly before the original ritual. He told them it was "a record of participation." He did not explain further. Most have had it in a drawer or on a shelf their entire lives. All of them know, on some level, what it is. Some have been waiting for someone to come for it.

The box in players' hands from this point forward. It is their progress tracker. Every cube added hums faintly. The hum deepens each time a new cube joins. Empty slots feel cold. Filled slots are warm.

The Diagnostic Puzzle - Each Stone's Echo

Each stone radiates a psychic echo - not a memory, but the Dawnborn's emotional stance on the ritual rendered as image and sensation. The stones are not recording. They are remembering, and they have been remembering the same night for fifty years.

Reading a stone: DC 12 Perception to detect the psychic aura; DC 14 Arcana to decipher the vision below. Touching a stone directly without checking deals 1d8 psychic damage - and the damage is the least of it. The toucher leaves carrying a splinter of the stone's grief: for the next hour, at the edge of every thought, there is a door closing, and a child's voice too faint to make out the words. It fades. It does not fade all the way.

When a player reads a stone, the stone reads them back. Nothing is taken, nothing is shown - but each player who succeeds understands afterward that they were seen, completely, for the space of a breath, and that the thing that saw them has been waiting fifty years to be looked at again.

STONE	VISION	WHAT IT REVEALS
Stone 1 - Sera Voss	A woman standing in a doorway. Already dressed to go out. She has been dressed for an hour. She is waiting for someone to tell her it is time.	She said yes. She is ready. She is waiting. Find her; she will give the cube immediately.
Stone 2 - Tomas Areth	A man at a desk covered in calculations, all checked and rechecked. One column crossed out and rewritten four times. The answer is the same each time. He cannot stop checking.	He knows the sequence. He fears it has an error he cannot find. Approachable; needs someone to trust the math with him.
Stone 3 - Ysel Maren	A woman looking back at an open door, calm and resolved in farewell.	Fully prepared for months. Surrenders the cube freely if treated with basic empathy.
Stone 4 - Cormac Drell	A man holding something invisible. His grip is very tight. He does not know if he is holding on or holding it back.	He said yes nine weeks ago. He does not know if he still means it. He has not examined it because examining it might break it. The cube is with him. He has not put it away.
Stone 5 - Lira Anwick	A pair of hands, and a smaller pair nested inside them. The smaller pair needs the larger pair to stay.	Someone depends on her. She believes leaving them is the thing she cannot do. The cube is at the Healing House. Approach gently; this is a harder conversation.
Stone 6 - Petra Vane	Darkness. The stone is cold. The impression is absent - not blocked, not hidden. She hasn't been seen in the city in three weeks.	She is the one they cannot find. Her location is Session 5's opening problem. Her cube will require finding her first.
Stone 7 - Nin Fletch	A road going in two directions at once. The figure at the crossroads stands still, as if the choice might resolve itself if left alone long enough.	They will say yes if asked directly and waited for. They have been waiting for an excuse not to choose. Remove the excuse: walk to them and ask.
Stone 8 - Orya Doss	A map with one location circled, then circled again, then again until	

STONE	VISION	WHAT IT REVEALS
	the paper is worn through at the center.	She knows where she needs to be. She has been ready. She simply has not told anyone. Go find her; she is probably already at home waiting.
Stone 9 - Aldric Stone	A forge. The heat is fine. Work is good. A man finishing a piece that was done three weeks ago. He keeps refining it because there is nothing else to do while he waits.	Already yes. Has been for years. The cube is in his apron pocket. He has been carrying it for three weeks. **Start here.**
Stone 10 - Davin Shore	Cold stone, silent and empty.	Dead for twenty years. His cube passed to his daughter Mira Shore outside the city (Session 5 objective).

Stone 6b (the Ixa position, marked by a hollow in the dais floor rather than a standing stone): no psychic image, only a persistent pocket of warm air - warmer than the other stones, warmer than the plaza, warm in a way that has nothing to do with the Ashring. Anyone who stands in that hollow for more than a moment finds their own breath coming easier, and does not know why, and does not want to step out.

The shared horror (reveal only if players read all ten stones): Each vision has a figure at its edge that none of the Dawnborn look at directly - a small figure, out of focus, the same one in every single vision. It is not in any of the assigned positions. It is standing where the hollow is. The stones do not know what it is. The stones only know that it was supposed to be there and wasn't, and that its absence is the reason the sun is still dark. Players who push at this (DC 17 Arcana) see the figure's face for a single instant - a tabaxi, adult, warm - and then it is gone, and the stone goes cold as if ashamed.

What players learn from a successful reading of all stones: - Priority order: Aldric (Stone 9, start here) → Sera, Ysel, Orya, Tomas, Nin Fletch (willing or near-willing) → Cormac (wavering, needs care) → Lira (harder) → Petra Vane (missing, Session 5) - Davin Shore's cube is with his daughter outside the city - the box can only be completed in Session 5 unless they go get it now - The box needs 8 cubes. They will not have all 8 today.

Also on the dais: The activation sequence - the order the cubes go into the box - is encoded in the dais's central star map carving. DC 15 Arcana to read the astronomical order (brightest to dimmest stars visible on the ritual night); Tomas Areth can assist (advantage).

But around the star map, cut into the stone in a hand that shook - Corven's - is a riddle. Read it aloud:

> *"Ten lights to hold the door. Nine that gave, and one that said no. Read them brightest to dimmest, and the order will not save you. What saves is the one who was never a star at all. She is not the last of the sequence. She is the reason there is a sequence."*

What the riddle means (do not tell players): The cubes are placed brightest-to-dimmest - that is the mechanical order. But the eleventh position, Ixa's, is not part of the star map and cannot be placed by the map's logic. She is "the one who was never a star." The riddle is Corven's confession, carved fifty years ago by a man who did not yet know what he was confessing to. Players who solve it now will carry it into Session 5. Players who don't will feel it click when Ixa steps onto the eleventh stone. Either way, it is the campaign's question, written in stone before anyone knew to ask it.

SCENE 3 - FIRST CUBE: ALDRIC AT THE FORGE

Five Senses & Setup

Players go directly to Aldric Stone - the Diagnostic showed them Stone 9 without ambiguity: already yes, already ready. His forge is in the Ashring District, three minutes from the circle. They can smell it before they see it: coal smoke, iron, the specific dry heat of active metalwork.

Five senses: - *Sight:* A wide forge open to the street, illuminated by hearthfire. A massive blacksmith in a leather apron shapes iron at his anvil. - *Sound:* Steady, rhythmic hammer blows echoing off stone walls. - *Smell:* Coal fumes, quenching water, hot iron. - *Touch:* Blasts of dry forge heat radiating into the chill street. - *Air:* Dry, smoky, and warm.

The Scene

On his workbench rest nine small, distinct iron tokens he has spent weeks crafting for his companions.

He completes his strike, racks his hammer, and faces the party:

> *"You've been to the stones. Before I hand over anything: do you know who you are asking? Not the city, not the sun. Them. By name."*

If players demonstrate they know the Dawnborn as individuals:

He counts the nine iron pieces into his palm and offers them forward:

> *"Find them. Give each one their token after they hand over their cube, not before. They must say yes to the work, not to me."*

If players treat them as generic objectives:

He turns back to his anvil: *"Learn who they are before you ask. They've lived with this for fifty years. You can take a day."*

He draws his cube from his apron; it pulses with innate magical warmth.

He holds it out in his open palm a moment before handing it over.

> *"Three mornings ago it started. When the stones began pulsing. I've been carrying this for three weeks and it was never warm until then."*

He looks at it.

> *"I think the ritual is already asking."*

He places it in the box himself. The slot accepts it. The box hums once (lower and different than before) and settles.

He rests his hand on the anvil:

> *"One more thing. At the circle, if anyone wavers, you stop. The ritual demands willing hearts, not coerced bodies. Promise me."*

He insists on their word before letting them leave.

What players gain: - Cube 1 (Slot 9), warm and active. - Nine forged tokens for the remaining Dawnborn. - A moral commitment that tests them during Cormac's, Lira's, and the final scene. - Confirmation that the ritual stones have begun awakening.

Aldric's intelligence (given after the promise, not before):

On Sera: "She's been ready longer than anyone. Don't go to her with a mission. Go to her with what you found at the stones."

On Cormac: "He's been at the Dawnhall since before dawn. Don't tell him it matters to me that he comes. Let him find his own reason."

On Lira: "She has someone. None of us have asked who." A pause that lasts too long. *"We should have asked."*

On Nin Fletch: "Give them time. Don't press. They'll come to yes if someone stands at the crossroads with them. They've never needed convincing; they've needed company."

On Petra Vane: "Three weeks. Nobody's seen her." He picks up the hammer. Does not strike. Sets it down. *"She wouldn't hide. She'd leave. Find her before someone else does."*

Tomas Areth - Cube Collection

Type: The Puzzle. He needs a second mind on the sequence before he can let go.

Want: An airtight, verified activation sequence. *Fear:* A calculation error that dooms the participants. *Lie:* "I have the sequence under control." In truth, he is terrified of a mistake.

Physical: Early forties, gaunt and ink-stained, surrounded by astronomical tables and dense notebooks.

Setup: He spots the puzzle box and stares in tense silence.

> *"Sit down. I need to show you something before we talk about the cube."*

He opens the notebook to the sequence page. Eight columns of star designations, astronomical notation from fifty years ago.

> *"This is the activation order. Brightest to dimmest, as they appeared on the ritual night. This is how the cubes go into the box. I have checked it four times. I cannot check it a fifth - I have looked at it too long to see it anymore. I need someone else to go through it with me."*

The Puzzle:

He hands over the star charts and a rubbing of the Ashring dais's central star map carving. The party works through the sequence to verify it.

Each of the eight positions is marked with a constellation symbol, and beneath each symbol, in Corven's cramped hand, is the constellation's old name in the pre-Twilight tongue. Tomas has spent forty years with these names and no longer sees them. A player who does will see what he can't: **the first letter of each name, read in order, spells a word.** In the correct order - brightest to dimmest - the eight names spell **FREEWILL**. Corven did not choose the sequence. He chose the word, and built the sequence to hide it.

But the copy Tomas has been checking carries a transposition - the sixth and seventh names swapped - so the acrostic no longer reads. The moment a player points at the two swapped symbols and says what the word is *supposed* to be, Tomas goes very still, and then something in his face breaks open in a way that is not relief. *"FREEWILL. He left us a word, not a formula."* He has been verifying arithmetic for forty years, and it was never arithmetic.

- **DC 14 Arcana** to work through the astronomical order independently.
- Advantage if players visited the Ashring dais this session and examined the star map.
- Tomas assists if asked, also grants advantage - but he cannot find the transposition himself. He has looked at it too long. Only a player's fresh eyes can catch it; this is the point of the scene.
- **On success:** The sequence confirms and the acrostic resolves to FREEWILL. The moment someone says it, Tomas catches the transposition: *"There. I have been staring at that for three days and my eye kept sliding past it."*
- **On failure:** 30 minutes of tedious recalculation produces the correct order - but the word is never found. The party gets the sequence without the confession, and they will not know, until Session 5, that the ritual's instruction was one word all along: free will. Tomas tolerates honest struggle, but bristles at carelessness.

After verification:

He pauses, digesting the Inversion's premise:

> *"Repeat that slowly. The part where everyone survives."*

He confirms three critical points: 1. *"Is Ellan Voss alive?"* [Yes - he thought she was dead or captured.] 2. *"All ten?"* [Confirmed - raises the mystery of the tenth vessel.] 3. *"Freely willing, without coercion?"* [Confirmed - he takes a minute to weigh his own choice.]

He sits in silent contemplation, ignoring interruptions until he has resolved his doubts.

He looks at the word on the page - FREEWILL - and something settles in him that is not comfort.

> *"Fifty years ago one of us said no. Ellan. And the whole thing stopped. He wrote the reason into the sequence, and none of us saw it until now. The ritual runs on people being free to refuse."*

He is quiet for a moment.

> *"Which means it can always stop again. Which means it was never going to be safe. I don't know whether that makes it easier to say yes or impossible."*

He does not expect an answer.

> *"I will give you the sequence. But understand this: if this fails, if it is nine voices instead of ten, the sequence is now in the wrong hands. Not yours. Anyone who comes after you. I am trusting you with the mechanism. Do not use it like one."*

Cube and verified sequence together. He does not separate them.

If players pressure him:

> *"I know coercion when I hear it. Come back when you can speak plainly."*

He refuses to budge until treated with respect.

Sera Voss - Cube Collection

Want: To complete the task she spent decades organizing. *Fear:* That her commitment is driven by guilt and obligation rather than true free will. *Lie:* "I am entirely ready." In truth, the isolation has taken a severe toll.

Physical: Forties, sharp, vigilant, speaking with practiced composure. Her cube rests in a dark stone case on the table.

Five senses: - *Sight:* An orderly room above the Quartermaster's office. Strategic district maps line the walls with marked dates. - *Sound:* Rustling parchment and steady city wind against the shutters. - *Smell:* Oak wood, black ink, and stone dust. - *Touch:* Well-oiled drafting table and cold stone floors. - *Air:* Chilled and still.

The scene: She greets the party without surprise: *"Which stones did you read this morning?"* She has monitored each Dawnborn for years and wants to know if the party grasped their conditions.

If players describe the stone echoes: she listens without correction. She already knows. Then:

> *"I've had this for fifty years. I put it on the table this morning because I thought today might be the day. But I need you to understand something first."*

She looks at the box.

> *"I know these people. I know what Cormac's wavering looks like and when it usually resolves. I know what Lira is protecting at the Healing House. I know that Tomas checked his sequence four times last night because I can hear his pen through the wall. I need to say yes because I want to - not because I know too much about what happens if I don't. So: do you want to know why I want to?"*

Unlock: Ask her why she wants to. Not "are you ready" - wrong question. Not urgency, not stakes. Just: *Why?*

If asked genuinely: *"Because I have spent twenty years making sure this was possible for other people. I would like to find out if I was right."* Cube goes freely.

If players invoke the mission, the city, or the stakes:

> *"You've come to the wrong conversation. I know the stakes in more detail than you do. Try again."*

She withholds the cube. DC 14 Insight: she resents being treated as a strategic instrument and wants her personal agency acknowledged.

After the cube: She hands over a current list of Dawnborn locations and states - she has been maintaining it. *"Aldric you've met. Try Ysel next. She's been ready longer than she's let on, and she's tired of no one noticing."*

Ysel Maren - Cube Collection

Want: Complete, unforced consent across all participants. *Fear:* That Cormac's hesitation will trigger a panic among the rest. *Lie:* "I have no doubts." In truth, she is hiding significant fear.

Physical: Tall Ashfen woman with a calm, imposing presence. Her cube is already secured in her pocket.

Five senses: - *Sight:* A secluded Dawnhall courtyard. Ysel sits on a stone bench, watching the amber sky. - *Sound:* Rhythmic kitchen clatter and muffled conversations inside. - *Smell:* Dried garden herbs, damp moss, kitchen smoke. - *Touch:* Chilled limestone bench. - *Air:* Crisp courtyard breeze.

The scene: She hears players arrive but doesn't turn immediately. When she does:

> *"Sera sent you, or the stones did. Doesn't matter. You found me."*

She reaches into her coat pocket. Does not hand the cube over yet.

> *"Ask me how I am."*

An earnest request from someone accustomed to carrying burdens alone.

Unlock: Ask her how she is coping. If asked with genuine interest:

> *"I've been ready for seven months, and no one thought to ask. Everyone was too busy managing Cormac."*

She surrenders the cube.

> *"His stone remains dark. He's been spiraling at the Dawnhall for three weeks. I'm going to confront him, but I'll let you speak with him first."*

If players treat her as a transaction: She pockets the cube: *"Wrong approach. Speak to me like a person or come back later."*

After the cube: Ysel heads to the Dawnhall, setting up the confrontation with Cormac in Scene 4.

Lira Anwick - Healing House Introduction (Full Scene in Session 5)

This is a setup scene only. Lira does not give her cube in Session 4. Players leave knowing where she is and what they're walking into.

Want: To ensure her patients are protected before she commits. *Fear:* That abandoning her clinic will result in preventable deaths. *Lie:* "I just need a few more days." In truth, she cannot bear to leave her ward.

Physical: Late forties, wearing an apron stocked with amber medicine vials, hands constantly busy with remedies.

Five senses: - *Sight:* Lowmark Healing House ward. Sickbeds along the wall, three occupied. Lira grinding herbs at a table. - *Sound:* Labored breathing, quiet clinking of vials, scraping pestle. - *Smell:* Crushed menthol, boiled bandages, pungent tinctures. - *Touch:* Smooth ceramic mortar and worn wooden counters. - *Air:* Warm, sterile, and herbal.

The scene: Lira sizes up the party immediately:

> *"You're not patients. I know why you're here. There is someone under my care who needs me, and I will not abandon them without handover. Return tomorrow. I must arrange coverage first."*

Outcome: Lira cannot be rushed today. This is an intended pacing beat, not a failed check. If pressed, she snaps:

> *"You can push, or I can come to you tomorrow with a yes. Choose."*

DC 14 Insight: she is not stalling. She is protecting someone, and she knows exactly what her yes means, and she is not afraid of it. She needs to make an arrangement before she steps away.

GM note: In Session 5, Lira arrives at the Ashring at dawn, cube in hand, alone. She made her arrangement. She will not explain it. If players ask: *"I found someone to stay."* That is all.

Nin Fletch - Cube Collection

Type: The Patience. They already know their answer. They needed someone to stand at the crossroads with them and ask directly.

Want: To break their habit of indecision. *Fear:* The finality of committing to a dangerous ritual. *Lie:* "I haven't made up my mind." In truth, they decided weeks ago.

Physical: Forties, slight, unobtrusive, keeping one hand jammed in a coat pocket around their cube.

Finding them: DC 10 Perception or Investigation locates them lingering at the busy Ashring-Lowmark intersection, watching the crowd.

The approach: Hard-sell persuasion fails here. If players rush in with apocalyptic urgency, Nin hesitates:

> *"I know. Give me a minute."*

If players wait patiently without lecturing, Nin relents:

> *"It's easier with someone here. I couldn't decide which way to go by myself. Both ways felt the same and then neither way felt like anything at all."*

Still not moving.

Unlock: One player asks, plainly: *"Are you coming?"*

No context needed. Just the question.

A pause. Long enough to be real.

> *"I've known for two weeks. I just needed someone to say it out loud."*

They take the cube from their left pocket. It has worn a groove in the lining from being taken out and put back many times.

> *"I kept hoping the decision would feel different once I'd made it. It doesn't feel like anything. Maybe that means it's real."*

Cube goes in the box. They do not wait to see where it sits. They are already looking back at the junction.

If players push aggressively: Nin falls quiet and looks away. The encounter requires patient roleplay rather than an intimidation or persuasion check.

Orya Doss - Cube Collection

Type: The Freebie. She decided a long time ago. No one asked.

Want: To hand over her cube and proceed. *Fear:* Being overlooked or forgotten. *Lie:* None. She is remarkably frank and pragmatic.

Physical: Late thirties, composed, waiting at her Primer Stone on the northern edge of the Ashring.

The arrival: She is already there when the party comes. Sitting on the carved base of her Primer Stone, legs folded, hands in her lap, watching the amber overhead. She looks like she has been sitting for hours, which she has, since the fourth bell, when she couldn't sleep and came here instead.

She sees the box from thirty feet out.

> *"Good. I was starting to think I'd have to come find you."*

She stands, brushes stone dust from her coat, and walks toward them without hurry.

> *"I've been here since the fourth bell. Couldn't sleep. Came here instead."*

She looks at the box.

> *"I decided a long time ago. I just hadn't told anyone, because no one had asked."*

She reaches into her coat. The cube is already in her hand.

> *"Same mouth, same choice."*

She places it in the box herself. Her Primer Stone responds before she steps back from it - a low tone, brief, like something settling into place. She looks back at it once.

> *"There. Now it knows too."*

She turns back to them.

> *"Cormac was at the Dawnhall two hours ago. Still sitting. You might want to get there before Ysel runs out of patience - in fairness, she has had enormous patience. But everyone has a limit."*

No check required: This is a clean, straightforward exchange after several challenging negotiations.

SCENE 3B - THE FLOWERING: PRIVATE APPROACH TO IXA

Five Senses & Setup

This scene triggers between Scenes 3 and 4 - after the party leaves Aldric's forge with the first cube, before they arrive at the Dawnhall. It is private: the letter arrives for Ixa specifically, not the party. How it is handled is her choice.

Five senses: - *Sight:* A pressed flower tucked into a doorway crack or resting on a window ledge at eye height - somewhere that could only have been left by someone watching Ixa specifically. One petal too many. The center darker than it should be. - *Sound:* Nothing. No one is nearby. The lane is empty. Someone was here a moment ago. - *Smell:* Something faintly botanical. Not unpleasant. Not right. - *Touch:* The letter paper is slightly warm - not from the sun. From being held. - *Air:* The sensation of being watched from a direction that has no one in it.

The letter: A handwritten note, no signature. The text matches the prop (recovered correspondence). Addressed to "the one who should not exist, but does."

Key lines: - *"We helped someone once. A woman in this city, many years ago, who loved someone the world said she was not permitted to love. We showed her it was possible. You are the outcome."* - *"We have been trying to make more outcomes like you. We have not always succeeded. The ones who did not succeed are still with us."* - *"Come to us. Or simply stop walking away. We will find each other."*

This is for Ixa's player. The letter tells her, implicitly, three things: (1) they know she exists and what she is, (2) they helped her mother conceive her, (3) they want her to come to them, not to stop the ritual or help it - just to be with her own kind. Whether Ixa shares the letter with the party is her choice.

If Ixa Ignores the Letter - The Flowering Sends

If Ixa does not respond, or if the party investigates the letter's origin and moves to shut down the approach, The Flowering sends what they send. This is not aggression in their understanding. It is retrieval.

What arrives: Two Grasping Tendrils - tragic, mutated subjects sent by the Flowering to grapple and abduct Ixa. They are not violent in intent; they are extremely violent in body, and they have been made this way by people who loved them and could not stop. They avoid lethality against Ixa, but the party are an obstacle - and an obstacle is something you walk through if it will not move. They will break limbs and crush ribcages and never once think of it as cruelty, because they are not thinking. They are retrieving.

Secondary Objective (state before combat begins): Prevent Ixa from being carried off. The Tendrils will attempt to grapple her exclusively - if one gets Ixa in a grapple and is not broken free within 2 rounds, a third Tendril emerges from a side alley to assist the escape. Protecting Ixa matters more than defeating the creatures. *And defeating them is going to feel like something the party wants to scrub off their hands afterward, because when these things stop moving, the party will have to look at what they were.*

Between the two combats (Scene 3b and Scene 5): If The Flowering combat runs long, compress Scene 4 (Cormac) to the key beat - Ysel's question, Cormac walking out, one player in the alley with him. The Reckoning escalation in Scene 5 is the session's climax and should not be cut.

Combat Cards - The Flowering's Failed Experiments

GRASPING TENDRIL *(×2, +1 if Ixa grappled for 2+ rounds) Medium aberration (formerly humanoid), unaligned*

A distorted bipedal horror with hyper-extended limbs and rubbery, translucent flesh. The joints bend past where joints should end, and when they bend you can hear the wet sound of things inside that should not articulate. Its mouth opens sometimes, and nothing that is a voice comes out, but the throat works, and it is trying to say something - it has been trying to say the same thing for a very long time. It lunges with eerie, fluid speed, fixating entirely on Ixa, and makes eye contact with her and only her.

AC 14 (natural armor) · **HP** 91 (14d8+28) · **Speed** 35 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	6 (-2)	10 (+0)	4 (-3)

Saving Throws Str +7, Con +5 · **Skills** Athletics +7, Stealth +6 **Damage Resistances** Bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical weapons **Condition Immunities** Charmed, frightened **Senses** Blindsight 30 ft., Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 10 · **Languages** None · **CR** 6 (2,300 XP)

TRAITS

Target Lock. The Tendril has designated Ixa as its retrieval target at the start of combat. It cannot be charmed or taunted away from her. If Ixa moves more than 60 ft. from the Tendril and breaks line of sight, it uses its full movement each turn to reacquire her.

Flexible Form. The Tendril can squeeze through spaces as small as 1 ft. wide without penalty. Opportunity attacks against it have disadvantage while it is squeezing.

Pack Retrieval. When two or more Tendrils are within 5 ft. of the same grappled target, both have advantage on Athletics checks to maintain or move the grapple.

Not Dead. At 0 HP, the Tendril does not die - it collapses, and it is still conscious. Its eyes stay open. Its hands keep reaching for Ixa, slowly, without strength. It is stable and will not bleed out; the Flowering will collect it later, unless the party does something about it first. A DC 14 Medicine check reveals what it once was - a person, altered down to the bone by decades of surgeries that were meant as love - and the check reveals that it is still in there, behind the eyes, watching, and that it knows what has been done to it and cannot say. One wears a plain iron ring on a finger that bends the wrong way. Another has a tattoo on its inner forearm, a child's name, cut through by whatever happened to the skin around it. *This is a person, not a monster. Describe the horror at full volume, and let the party sit with what killing one actually means.*

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Two Grasping Slam attacks, or one Grasping Slam + one Constrict (if a creature is already grappled).

Grasping Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 11 (2d6+4) bludgeoning damage. If the target is Large or smaller, it is grappled (escape DC 16). The Tendril can have up to two creatures grappled at once. *The blow lands wrong - the arm doesn't swing so much as unfold, and the sound of it connecting is wet.*

Constrict. *Automatic - grappled target only.* The grappled target takes 13 (2d8+4) bludgeoning damage and must succeed on DC 15 Strength saving throw or be restrained until the grapple ends. *The limbs close like a fist, and for a moment the target can feel the individual bones of the hand against their own.*

Snap (replaces one Grasping Slam - restrained target only). The Tendril twists a limb against the joint. The restrained target takes 15 (3d6+4) bludgeoning damage and must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, the limb is broken - the target has disadvantage on attack rolls and ability checks using that limb until it receives magical healing or completes a long rest with a successful DC 15 Medicine check. *The sound is the worst part. It carries.*

Haul (Bonus Action - grappled target only). The Tendril moves up to its full speed, dragging the grappled target with it. This movement does not provoke opportunity attacks from the dragged creature.

REACTIONS

Interpose. When a creature the Tendril can see targets Ixa with an attack, the Tendril moves up to 10 ft. (no opportunity attacks) and imposes disadvantage on the attack by placing itself between them. Can only trigger once per round.

> *Tactics, Round 1: Move directly to Ixa, Grasping Slam twice. Round 2: Constrict if grappled, Haul toward the nearest exit. Round 3: If pack retrieval active, one Tendril holds Ixa while the other clears the path - and it clears the path through people, not around them. Third Tendril (if triggered) appears in the alley behind the primary exit route - it is already in position. It has been there since the letter was left.*
>
> *The Tendrils do not respond to Intimidation, Persuasion, or Deception. They respond to damage and to Ixa voluntarily going with them - if Ixa says she will come willingly, both Tendrils stop immediately and stand aside. They wait, and one of them reaches toward her with a hand that shakes.*

After combat: If the party defeats the Tendrils, the creatures are down but not gone - still breathing, still watching Ixa. What the party does next is the moral question of the scene. If they examine the downed: DC 12 Investigation finds a second pressed flower tucked into the larger Tendril's clothing. One petal too many. Center dark. This one has writing on it: *"We will try again. We always do. Please just stop walking away."*

The party will have to decide whether to finish them. These are not monsters. They are the Flowering's failures - people who were loved into this and kept alive because the Flowering does not abandon what it begins. A player who kills one to end its suffering has done a mercy. A player who kills one because it is easier than carrying it has done something the campaign will remember differently. A player who walks away and leaves it reaching for Ixa in the gutter has done something third. There is no clean answer. That is the point.

If Ixa asks to go with them: This is a player choice with major Session 5 consequences. The Flowering will receive her warmly. They will tell her everything. They will not let her leave without effort. This is a separate track for Session 5, do not resolve it here.

SCENE 4 - RP: CORMAC'S WAVERING

Five Senses & The Encounter

NPC: Cormac Drell (with Ysel Maren present and watching)

Cormac Drell - Stocky dockworker in his mid-thirties, restless and visibly strained, gripping an empty clay mug.

Ysel Maren - Tall Ashfen woman watching him with unblinking, calm resolve.

Want: To not have to look at his own yes. **Fear:** That when he finally looks, he will find it was never courage - that saying yes was a way to die without having to do it himself, and he is not brave enough to admit the difference. **Lie:** "I stand by what I told Edoran." He isn't sure there was ever a self standing behind that yes at all.

Setup: Players enter the Dawnhall to find Cormac seated at the communal table with Ysel watching from across the bench. As the party steps in, Ysel breaks the silence: *"Do you still mean what you told Edoran?"*

Five senses: - Sight: Amber lantern light. The long Dawnhall table. Cormac's hands around a clay cup. - Sound: Food sounds from the kitchen. The specific silence of a room waiting for someone to speak. - Smell: Warm bread. Lamp oil. Old wood. - Touch: The bench worn smooth where many people have sat for years. Clay cups warm from the kitchen. - Taste: Watered cider set out without asking. Slightly sour. Well-intentioned. - Air: Old timber and smoke. The warmth of a room that feeds a lot of people.

The Encounter Beat: Cormac freezes, sets his cup down, and leaves through the rear door into the alley. The cup doesn't fall over. He set it down with both hands, carefully, the way you set something down you might need to pick up again.

Players who follow him find him leaning against the damp brick wall outside, eyes closed. If an adventurer listens without demanding excuses, he admits:

> *"I said yes when I thought it would happen fast. Having weeks to think about it broke my nerve."*

Then, if they stay, the darker thing - the thing he has not said to anyone, not even Ysel:

> *"Do you want to know the part I can't look at? When I said yes to Edoran, I wasn't sure it was courage. I was never sure. A man can want to save his city, or he can want to be done with his own life, and from the inside those two things look exactly the same. I said yes nine weeks ago and I still don't know which one it was."*

Resolution: This is a roleplay interaction rather than a dice roll. The wrong question is *"Will you still do it?"* - that only makes him set the cup down again. The right question is *"Why did you say yes in the first place?"* - and then the party must be able to hear an answer that has no heroism in it. Cormac does not need to be reassured that he is brave. He needs someone to sit with the possibility that he wasn't, and to stay anyway. If a player does that - asks the question, and stays through the ugly answer - he regains his footing and commits: flag "Cormac: renewed."

The flag is the important part. A Cormac who is "renewed" has examined his own consent and chosen it again, not for the city but for the people he said yes to. That is the difference between Ending B and Ending A.

Ysel after the scene: Ysel watches the outcome in silence, allowing Cormac's choice to stand on its own merits.

If players do not follow up before Session 5 closes: his stone is dark at the Inversion Circle. The Inversion cannot complete.

Sample dialogue: - Ysel (opening): *"Do you still mean what you told Edoran?"* - Cormac (if pressed before he's ready): *"I need you to stop asking me that."* - Cormac (most honest): *"I said yes when I thought it would be over before I had time to think about it again. It kept not being over."* - Cormac (the part he can't look at): *"I don't know if I was saving the city or just done with myself. And I'm afraid to find out which, because if it's the second one, then saying yes again isn't sacrifice. It's just… giving up, with everyone watching."* - Cormac (after being asked *why* and heard out): *"Because I told nine people I would. And because they've been patient with me for three weeks. That's not a good reason. It's the only one I've got that's true."*

How it connects forward: Cormac is one of the ten Dawnborn. His consent status determines whether Ending B is achievable. Players who treat this scene as a logistics problem will not reach him.

Aldric Stone - Dawnborn

Want: To help. He has already chosen; his consent is the clearest of all ten. *Fear:* That he chose wrong. Not whether to participate, but whether his participation will be enough. *Lie:* "I am not afraid of dying." In truth, he fears dying in vain.

Voice: Low, firm, and unhesitating. *"I said yes. I meant it. I mean it now."*

Physical: Late fifties, broad-shouldered blacksmith with glowing amber eyes matching the ritual stones. He radiates a noticeable, comforting warmth. Completely composed and resolved.

He has been at his Primer Stone three mornings this week. When his hand touches it, it responds faster and warmer than for any other Dawnborn. He hasn't mentioned this. It doesn't seem like the kind of thing that needs mentioning.

Lira - Dawnborn

Not present in Session 4's Dawnhall scenes. If players ask Aldric who's missing: *"Lira hasn't come. She knows. She just hasn't said yes yet."* He says it without judgment. He does not elaborate.

If players press: *"She has someone who needs her. I'm not going to make that easier or harder for her."*

Players who visit the Healing House during Session 4: she is polite. She asks them to leave. She is not ready. This is the setup for Session 5 Scene 3 - players who have met Lira and know where she is will be prepared when they need to go to her.

Want: To make a decision she can stand behind when it is over. *Fear:* That the person who needs her is the reason she can't say yes: and that both things are simultaneously true. *Lie:* "I need more time." She has run out of time. She knows it.

Petra Vane - Dawnborn

Not present at the Dawnhall. Players can learn her location from Tomas (he knows where all the Dawnborn are: *"Petra's in Greenhollow. Third ward. She's not avoiding anyone - she just doesn't come to group meetings"*) or from Edoran (DC 11 Persuasion). She does not need to be visited in Session 4. In Session 5, she arrives at the Ashring at dawn - she has already decided. Players who know her location are not surprised; players who don't will find an unfamiliar face at one of the stones.

SCENE 5 - COMBAT: THE CONCORDANCE MOVES

Setup & Secondary Objective

Before the scene: At dusk, the Ashring's hum is dead silent. DC 13 Arcana detects an active magical dampening field siphoning energy from the stones. The air near the Ashring tastes of copper, like the inside of a mouth.

Setup: Evening. Players return to the Ashring with however many cubes they have gathered. The Concordance has been watching all session. The morning cell was a warning. This is not a warning. A senior Concordance cell has moved into the Ashring site - they arrived while the party was at the Dawnhall. There are seven of them: four Unlit operatives, two Priests of the Inward Crescent, and a single figure standing at the central dais who has not moved since they arrived. The dais is surrounded by a circle of obsidian powder, laid in a line fine as a thread and dark as a closed eye. The Concordance Stone's hiding hollow has been found and opened. The hollow is empty - they have not found the box itself, because the players have it. They are waiting.

There is blood on the flagstones near the hollow - not much, not Aldric's. Someone else tried to stop this before the party arrived, and the Concordance dealt with them quietly and left them somewhere out of sight.

Aldric Stone stands trapped inside the obsidian circle, guarded by silent priests who have hemmed him in with suppressive runes. He has not been bound and he has not been hurt, and he has stood there for forty minutes while the priest nearest him said nothing at all - which is worse than threats.

Secondary Objective (state before combat begins): Get Aldric out of the obsidian circle before the Priests complete the suppression ritual they have been building. The circle is not finished - they needed the Concordance Stone to anchor it and they don't have it. They are improvising. If Aldric is inside the circle when it completes (end of round 4 if uninterrupted), his connection to his Primer Stone is severed for 24 hours. *And the severing is not painless. It is a spiritual amputation. Aldric will not scream. He will go very white and very still, and the light will go out of him the way a wick takes. A week ago he was the warmest man in the city; tonight he is just cold.* He cannot give his cube's consent-link without the connection. He becomes the ritual's missing piece.

Enemies: - Unlit Operative ×4: Use the stat block from Scene 1. - Priest of the Inward Crescent ×2: See NPC block below. - Null-Warden ×1 (standing at the dais): See NPC block below. This is the most dangerous combatant the party has faced. It does not move until round 2.

The Opening - Before Initiative

The Null-Warden turns from the dais - an elderly shadar-kai with weathered obsidian eyes, wearing an exposed crescent talisman. There is a settled, terrible calm to it, the calm of something that has already imagined this fight ending and is not troubled by the shape of it.

They speak. Not loudly.

> *"You have the Stone. We know you have the Stone. We are not going to take it from you tonight."*

A pause. The four Unlit have not moved.

> *"What we are going to do is make sure the door stays closed. Whatever it costs. However long it takes. The passage is complete. We are the passage now."*

They look at Aldric.

> *"He understands. He has had forty minutes to understand. Ask him yourself, if you like. We did not threaten him. We explained what will happen if this goes forward, and he is still here, which means he is either very committed or he has not entirely made up his mind. We find both outcomes acceptable."*

They look back at the party, and something moves behind the grey of their eyes - not anger, not fear. Certainty.

Then the Priests begin the suppression circle (murmuring, the obsidian powder shifting) and the Null-Warden turns back to the dais.

Social path: DC 17 Persuasion (or revealing that the Unmoved One's true goal is corruption, not prevention) causes one of the Priests to stop. The other continues. The Null-Warden does not turn. What the stopping Priest does next (relay it upward, defect, do nothing) depends on what the party says in the next thirty seconds. This is not a guaranteed out. It is a crack. *And if the party hesitates too long trying to talk their way out, the ritual finishes around Aldric and the crack closes.*

Combat Cards - Priests & Null-Warden

PRIEST OF THE INWARD CRESCENT *(×2) Medium humanoid (shadar-kai), lawful neutral*

AC 14 (chain shirt) · **HP** 97 (15d8+30) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	18 (+4)	13 (+1)

Saving Throws Wis +7, Int +6 · **Skills** Arcana +6, Religion +6, Insight +7, Perception +7 **Damage Resistances** Necrotic · **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 17 · **Languages** Common, Elvish, Undercommon · **CR** 7 (2,900 XP)

Spellcasting. Wisdom (save DC 15, +7 to hit).

Cantrips: toll the dead, guidance, sacred flame, spare the dying *1st (4 slots):* bane, inflict wounds, detect magic, shield of faith *2nd (3 slots):* hold person, silence, spiritual weapon *3rd (3 slots):* dispel magic, spirit guardians, counterspell *4th (2 slots):* banishment, death ward

TRAITS

Suppression Ritual (Concentration, Active). While both Priests are alive and within 10 ft. of each other, they are building the obsidian circle. Each round they are uninterrupted, the circle completes one step further. At step 4: Aldric's stone connection severs. Breaking the ritual requires dealing 20+ damage to one Priest in a single hit, or physically breaking the obsidian powder line.

Doctrinal Certainty. Immune to charm. Advantage on saves vs. spells that compel truth or alter belief.

Shadow Step (Bonus Action, Recharge 5–6). Teleport up to 30 ft. between dim/dark spaces.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Two attacks: Toll the Dead + Spiritual Weapon, or two Inflict Wounds.

Toll the Dead. One creature within 60 ft.: DC 15 Wis save or 9 (2d8) necrotic, 2d12 if missing HP.

Inflict Wounds (melee). *+7 to hit,* reach 5 ft.: 22 (4d10) necrotic. *The Priest's hand does not touch the target - the flesh beneath it dims and withers, skin going grey and dry as winter, and the wound it leaves does not bleed the way a cut bleeds. It bleeds the way a corpse would, if it still could.*

Spiritual Weapon (2nd slot, Bonus Action). Spectral obsidian blade appears within 60 ft. Lasts 1 minute. +7 to hit, 1d8+4 force on hit. Move up to 20 ft. and attack as bonus action each turn.

Spirit Guardians (3rd slot). 15-ft radius around self: creatures entering or starting turn there make DC 15 Wis save or take 18 (4d8) necrotic. Concentration.

Banishment (4th slot). One creature within 60 ft.: DC 15 Cha save or banished 1 minute (concentration).

REACTIONS Counterspell (3rd slot, interrupt spell within 60 ft.).

> *Tactics: Priests stay adjacent, building suppression ritual every round as bonus action. One Priest handles Spiritual Weapon + Toll the Dead. One handles Spirit Guardians around Aldric's position. Neither moves more than 10 ft. from the obsidian circle while the ritual is active. If forced out of range: ritual pauses, both reorient to reestablish adjacency before attacking. They do not acknowledge the party as people. They are performing a sacred task, and the party are the noise at the edge of it - and when a Priest finishes a downed enemy, it is an act of worship, not cruelty, and that is somehow worse.*

NULL-WARDEN *(×1) Medium humanoid (shadar-kai), lawful neutral*

A premier Concordance enforcer tasked with crushing ritual energy. Wields a scarred iron-and-obsidian null-focus rod.

AC 19 (plate armor) · **HP** 161 (19d8+76) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)

Saving Throws Str +9, Con +8, Wis +7 · **Skills** Athletics +9, Perception +7, Arcana +7 **Damage Resistances** Necrotic; Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing from nonmagical weapons **Condition Immunities** Charmed, frightened · **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 17 · **Languages** Common, Elvish · **CR** 11 (7,200 XP)

TRAITS

Null Aura. Creatures within 10 ft. of the Warden cannot cast spells of 1st level or higher without succeeding on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw. On failure: the spell slot is expended and the spell fails.

Shadow Step (Bonus Action, Recharge 4–6). Teleports up to 30 ft. between dim/dark spaces. Arrives with advantage on next melee attack.

Ritual Anchor. While the Warden holds the null-focus and stands within 10 ft. of the Ashring dais, the suppression circle builds two steps per round instead of one (counts as if both Priests acted, stacks).

Immovable Resolve. Cannot be moved against its will by any effect that doesn't first deal 30+ damage in a single hit.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Four Null-Focus Strike attacks, or three Null-Focus Strike + one Null Pulse.

Null-Focus Strike. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +9 to hit, reach 10 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d6+5) bludgeoning + 9 (2d8) necrotic. On hit, target cannot cast spells using reactions until start of its next turn. *The wounds it leaves are wrong - they don't close properly, the skin around them going grey at the edges, and healing magic stings going in. A creature struck by the Warden heals for half from spells until it completes a long rest.*

Null Pulse (Recharge 5–6). 20-ft radius, centered on self: DC 17 Constitution save or all ongoing concentration spells within range end immediately. Creatures with active spells that end this way take 18 (4d8) psychic damage. *The pulse is silent and total. Casters in the radius feel their own magic torn out of them, and for a heartbeat they forget the words for things - their own name, the way home. It passes. The ringing it leaves lasts for hours.*

Seal the Stone (1/day, Action). Targets one Primer Stone within 30 ft. The stone's connection to its Dawnborn is severed for 24 hours. Cannot be used if a Dawnborn is actively touching the stone. *When the Warden does this, the targeted Dawnborn - whether in the circle or across the plaza - feels the thing that has been alive in them since the night they were born go out. It is not pain. It is worse. It is the moment a person understands, by its absence, what has been keeping them company their entire life. This is what the Warden came to do if the suppression circle fails.*

REACTIONS

Null Response. When a spell is cast within 30 ft., the Warden may move up to 15 ft. toward the caster without provoking opportunity attacks (no action required).

> *Tactics, Does not move until round 2. Round 1: Stands at the dais. Does not act offensively. The Null Aura is active. Let players feel it - the way a spell dies on their lips, the cold weight of the Warden's presence. Round 2: Shadow Steps to the most dangerous spellcaster. Three Null-Focus Strikes + hold position. Round 3+: Maintain adjacency to highest-threat target, Null Pulse when 3+ concentration spells are up. Seal the Stone if Aldric's player attempts to reach the stone without the party's protection. At 50 HP: states flatly - "You are stronger than anticipated. The record will reflect this." Does not stop fighting. It will not surrender and it will not bargain. When it finally falls, it does not die quickly - it goes down on one knee, then the other, and the grey of its eyes fades last, and it is still looking at the party when it goes.*

Combat End & Session Hook

Combat ends when: The Null-Warden reaches 0 HP (the Priests and Operatives withdraw immediately) or the suppression circle is broken (the cell's purpose is gone - they leave). If the Null-Warden is captured and conscious: it answers three direct questions truthfully, then refuses to speak further. It does not know the Unmoved One's true nature. It believes the doctrine. The three answers it gives will be precise, accurate, and deeply unsettling. *It will not be broken further. The Obsidian Ring the party took in Scene 1 would break a person's personality; this one has already been emptied of everything except the doctrine, and there is nothing left to invert.*

If the circle completes before Aldric is freed: Aldric's Primer Stone goes dark for 24 hours, and Aldric himself is diminished in a way that has nothing to do with the ritual - a week ago he was the warmest man in the city, and tonight he is just cold. The ritual is delayed into Session 5 without causing an automatic failure, but the cost is written on a person the party watched stand very still in a circle for forty minutes and say nothing.

Session hook: With the Concordance routed, the puzzle box resonates sharply, aligning with the Ashring stones as the first stage of the Inversion locks into place. And somewhere in the plaza, a body the party didn't notice when they arrived is still cooling - the Concordance did that quietly, and no one is coming to collect it but the dawn.

END OF SESSION

What players now know: - The Concordance of the Withdrawn has been tracking the Dawnborn by designation for years. The surveillance predates the party's involvement entirely. - The Concordance is capable of direct action at the Ashring. The morning cell was a warning. The evening was not. - The Null-Warden exists. The Concordance has purpose-built tools for severing Dawnborn-stone connections. - The Inversion path (Ending B) exists and is mechanically possible: all ten Dawnborn at their stones, unanimous genuine

consent, no one dies. - The Inversion path requires Cormac's renewed consent, Lira's consent, Petra Vane's consent, and several others, all of whom have not given it yet. - The Flowering has found whoever they were looking for. The letter went to someone specific.

What they carry forward: Cormac's unresolved doubt and the looming escalation at the Ashring.

Session debrief question: *"When someone chooses to sacrifice themselves, what do you owe them? Acceptance? Protection? Something else?"*

Consequence tracker:

ELEMENT	STATE
Concordance asset list	Recovered (designations known) / not recovered (surveillance scope unknown)
Obsidian Ring of Contrariwise	Recovered / not recovered
Primer Stones activated	Yes: Inversion inscription revealed / No: inscription unread
Cormac's status	Renewed consent / unresolved (stone dark in Session 5)
Aldric's stone connection	Intact / severed 24 hrs (suppression circle completed)
Null-Warden	Defeated / withdrew / captured (3 answers given)
Ixa, The Flowering letter	Shared with party / kept private / ignored / accepted
Petra Vane	Location known (Greenhollow) / unknown

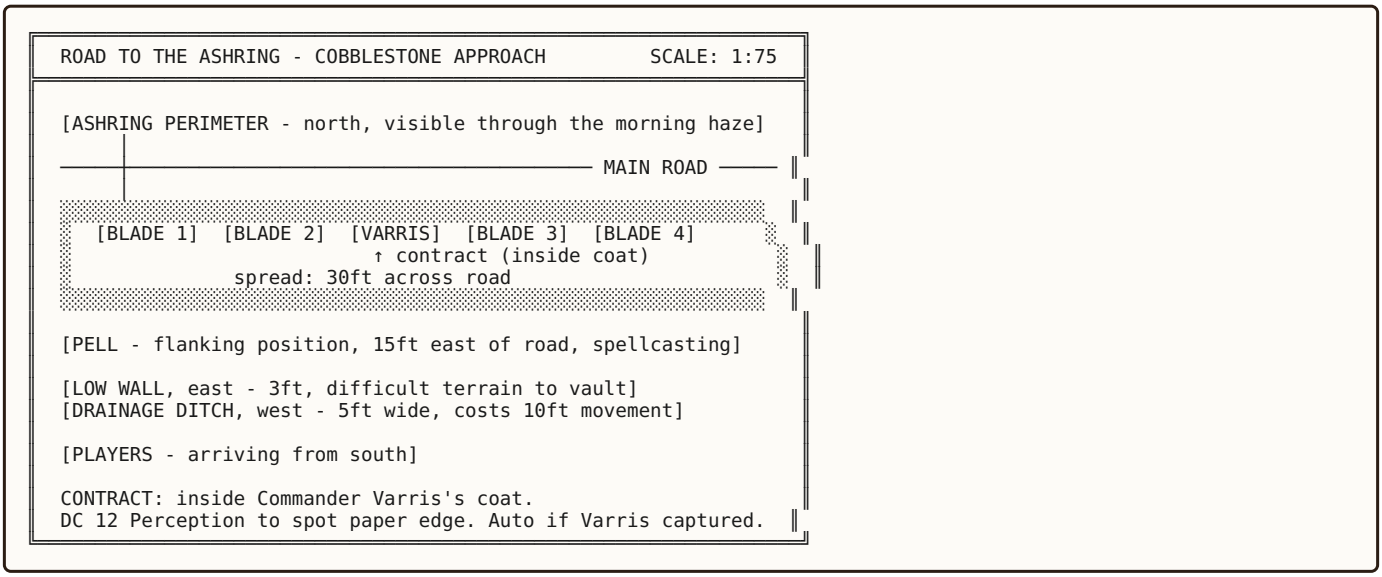
The Restorers as allies: If players share evidence of either faction's true agenda with Brother Edoran or Maerin Voss, the Restorers become active allies - sanctuary, intelligence, bodies at the ritual site. Edoran is the most dangerous kind of enemy to the Concordance: a genuine true believer who has just been told his enemy is the opposite of sacred. He will not be quiet about it. DC 13 Persuasion to activate this, or simply show him the Concordance prop and tell him what the Unmoved One actually wants.

What they don't know yet: - The Unmoved One is an ancient Lich seeking to corrupt the Inversion at its climax, using the unwitting Concordance as its front. - The Flowering's mutated tendrils are former members deformed by experiments, sheltered rather than abandoned. - Ellan will consent once all ten Dawnborn have freely committed to the circle. - With eleven known Dawnborn for ten stones, one individual must voluntarily step aside in Session 5.

SESSION 4 TACTICAL REFERENCE MAPS

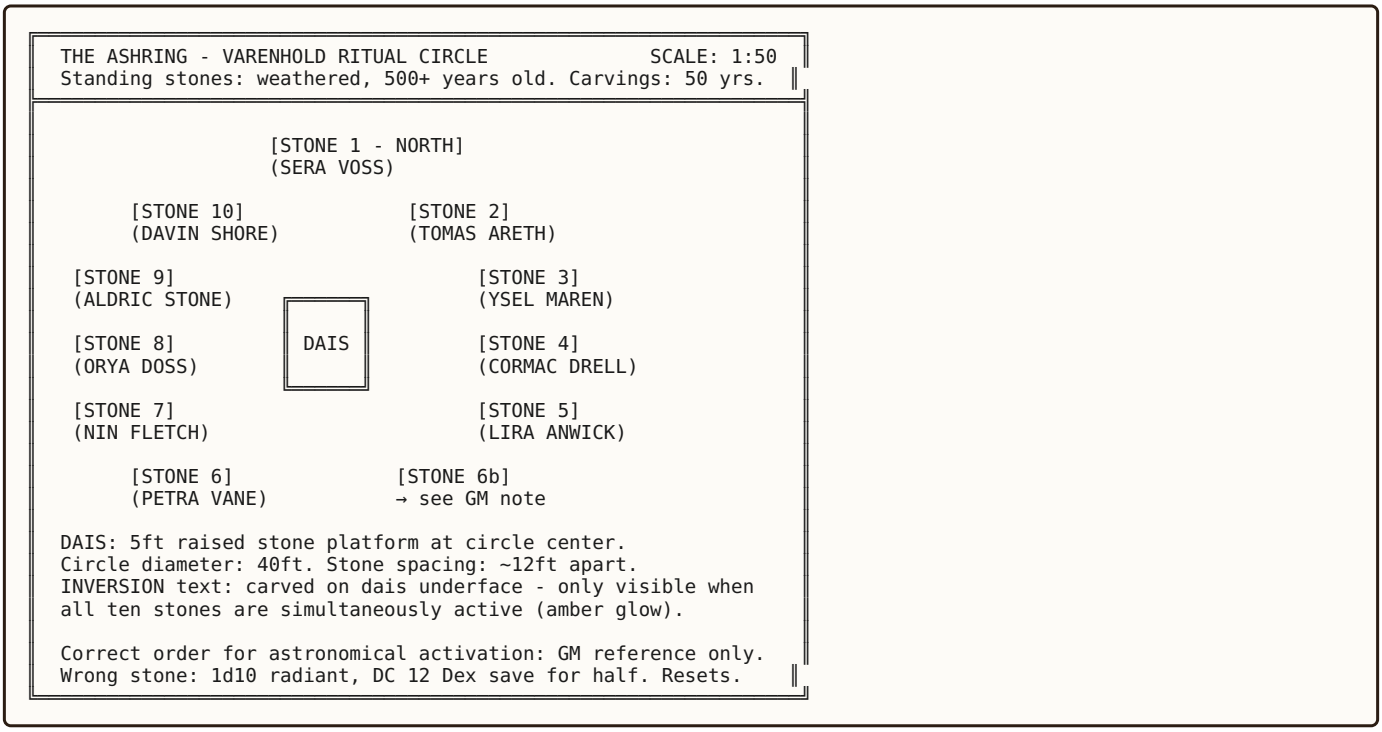
Road to the Ashring - Solennite Intercept (Scene 1)

GM reference for Scene 1 combat. Show to players or describe verbally. Six Blades in professional intercept formation, not a barricade, a negotiation with consequences.



The Ashring - Primer Stone Positions (Scenes 2, 3, 5)

Hand to players when they reach the Ashring perimeter. Leave on table for Scenes 2, 3, and 5. The stone labels are unlabelled by Dawnborn name until players learn the assignment, add names as discovered.



Activation sequence (GM only): brightest to dimmest stars visible on the night of the original ritual. Three source routes: Observatory records (DC 13 Persuasion with Maret Lonn, or DC 15 Thieves' Tools), Corven's combined Notation Key (Fragments 1+2, advantage on DC 12 Arcana), or Tomas Areth (gives it freely if asked - but triggers the Inversion conversation).

Inversion inscription on the dais underface: "If all ten give the word freely, the word becomes the sun." This is Ending B in plain language.

Dawnhall - Common Room, Scene 4 (Cormac)

